The Ultimate guide to Self-confidence



JAMES HAFORLARIN

NOTES FROM THE AUTHOR

I wrote this book as a guide for people stuck in shyness and social-anxiety as an easy way out. I had a difficult struggle with shyness and I wouldn't wish that for anyone if I can help it. I wouldn't mind if you share this book with a friend that you think needs it.

You will find more of my content on my blog

As always thanks for reading.

James

9 things this Guide will teach you

1. How to stay clear of the common mistakes people make
2. What genuine confidence is
3. The difference between shyness and introversion
4. The main obstacles to confidence and how to overcome them
5. How to go beyond FEAR and negative thoughts
6. How to effectively grow genuine confidence
7. The single practice that trumps willpower and motivation
8. How to accelerate your confidence growth
9. And most importantly, how to put all these into use in your life.


WHY IS IT
SO
HARD TO BE
CONFIDENT
CHAPTER ONE

All my life I've always wondered and I'm sure you have wondered too

- ❖ Why can't I approach that woman
- ❖ Why can't I get up on that stage and kill the speech
- ❖ Why can't I pick up the phone and call those prospects
- ❖ Why do I get so scared easy
- ❖ Am I a chicken and is this just a curse I have to deal with for the rest of my life.

I don't know about you or the reason you are reading this but I grew up extremely shy.

I couldn't approach women or talk too loud so people won't notice and reject shy me. I didn't get to ask a lady out until I was 20 years old. I passed on a lot of life wonderful opportunities because I couldn't man up and be brave.

I was always challenged with this question. Why is it so hard to be confident?

Imagine what I could accomplish if I had 10x more confidence? 100x? I would be Unstoppable!

I tried my best to force myself to be confident and let me just say it didn't turn out too well. I spent money on books, online courses, blogs, e-books and consumed countless YouTube videos.

All I had to show for it were superficial tips that didn't work for too long.

I would get fired up by these tips and then in a few weeks I was back to my old shy miserable self.

However, lately things changed as I sorted through all the lies we are being told everyday about how to build confidence in blogs, books and everyday videos.

I finally got ideas that have not only worked for me but for countless of others. I got to understand how my mind worked, what confidence is, what are the blocks and what I could do to get more of it.

I've been able to approach women(over 100 to be precise), cold call mentors, showcase my writing to the world and give class speeches in my local college..

I know you're probably overwhelmed about what to do to build your own so called illusive confidence and I'm here to guide you through all I've found and what's worked for me.

I want to take a second to think about how your life would be if you were 5x 10x 100x more confident. Because, that is what will happen by the time you finished reading this book.

Let's get started.

THE COMMON MISTAKES YOU WANT TO AVOID



CHAPTER TWO

You know when we were kids and we used to believe in ghosts, Santa Claus and vampires. We still have beliefs like that in relation to how to build confidence. I know now what a big block this false beliefs are and how they cripple people in life so that's where we start. There are four really common ones. We will look into each, see if any correlates with you and we'll both realize how each of them are such a bad idea.

1. OVERNIGHT SUCCESS

In 2010, Phillippa Lally and her team of researchers of the university College London conducted a study aimed at getting to the bottom of the popular question of how long it takes to really make a lasting habit/lifestyle change.

You know as scientist does, they tracked 96 people over 12 weeks as those people attempted to make a daily lifestyle change. These awesome researchers debunked the popular myth that it takes just 21 days to change your life as the gurus have popularized, it's a lie because they found out it takes an average of 66 days until the new behavior reaches peak level of automaticity. With some habits taking 18 days while some extreme habits took over 200 days!

We all love the sound of overnight successes right? You know, miraculously change, become super-confident and kill all your gigantic goals in one mega try.

I would certainly love you to change miraculously. Just be able to get in your brain and make you confident enough to get up unto a world stage and give a stunning speech without practice.

We are bombarded with promises of instant change and because we are so desperate (and lazy) we fall for it like a sheep on a leash.

Changing your life and any habit in 21 days is a lie!

The truth however is that it doesn't take 21 days, 30 or 43, all those promises are BS and you have to know right now that making a lasting change to your lifestyle. Bringing in more confidence will take time and continuous effort. There is no trick to this, trust me I've searched everywhere.

If you're interested in those 21, close this book now and go find something else.

2. MAGICAL DISSAPEARANCE OF FEAR

Remember the first time you tried to swim? If you're anything human, on your first day you would be extremely self-conscious. Your mind will come up with all the possible ways it could go wrong, how you would drown, make an embarrassment of yourself and fail to get it right and how everyone will find your pitiful trials to swim as hilarious.

Then, as you started practicing, this self-consciousness don't just evaporate, it only reduces. As soon as you master a stroke, your swimming confidence rises.

Fast forward to 2 months of swimming practice and you will be able to dive into the water without any thought in the world, laugh and have a nice time. By this time you're 90-100% confident.

This brings us to the other way we fall of the track of building our confidence. People are so busy looking for ways to make their discomfort dissappear. With the wide-spread popularity of NLP and psycho hypnosis, we are made to believe that our fears can miraculously vanish.

Magical dissappearance of fear is a lie!

It's another bullshit that's being spread around. I spent hundreds of dollars getting resources about how to dissolve my fear, and I know about others who are still in this trap. I want

to snap you out of it.

Some are still waiting for the time they get the feeling of confidence before they act. However the truth is that confidence comes only after you gain competence.

There is a term for it in psychology and that it the competence confidence loop. That is the more you practice, the more you gain competence at that thing and with competence comes increased confidence. Look into every area of your life that you're confident now and you'll see this to be true- language, driving, swimming, drawing, writing, knotting a tie etcetera.

3. JUST DO IT!

Nike told us to just do it!

Self help gurus, parents, friends and all of them just tell us to miraculously man up and just do it in one earth-shattering moment. These people mean well but as you now know, things doesn't work that way.

According to one evil study performed 40 years ago by a Walter Michel, a professor of Columbia University. He and his team of researchers presented preschoolers with a plate of marshmallow. The child was then told that he would get a double treat of marshmallows if he could wait until the researchers get back.

Some of the kids couldn't wait and they ate the marshmallow the instant the researcher stepped out of the room, some kids did everything to distract themselves from the treat by playing or closing their eyes, some even resorted to chanting, some eventually succumbed after a long time and few of them managed to survive long enough for the researcher to come back. No what do I have to bring out from this is this, we don't all have the same level of Willpower. Some people can will themselves to talk to that stranger. But they are not our role models.

Most of us would never be able to manage this.

Just do it is a lie!

Widespread research and my personal life has made understand that brute force Willpower is highly overrated. Motivation is a better tool to help us make lasting change in our life.

Things like;

- ❖ Having a clear purpose and knowing why you want more confident
- ❖ Having the right estimation of the discomfort you're going to go through
- ❖ Knowing more about your mind process and how to handle it.
- ❖ Getting into a supportive environment and
- ❖ Breaking down the process into bite size chunks are better ways to motivate ourselves to take action, not some mysterious willpower.

4. SWEET AFFIRMATIONS

Just imagine you stood in front of a mirror for 20 minutes and repeated

I'm a very confident pilot

I feel no fear of flying

I'm cool and calm in the air

I'm born to be courageous pilot

I attract confidence from every corner of the globe(Okay maybe not this one)

Everyday in every way I'm getting better and better.

Can you now go out and fly a plane confidently accepting the fact that you have never flown a plane before?

Self-Affirmations to build confidence don't work. It's as simple as that. I'm not advocating that self-affirmation are useless, I believe in using Affirmations to motivate ourselves to be happy and feel centered, but in the aspect of growing your confidence. It has zero value. You can repeat mantras from now until eternity and sure you'll end feeling centered and calm but nothing will happen. It wouldn't spur you to take any action.

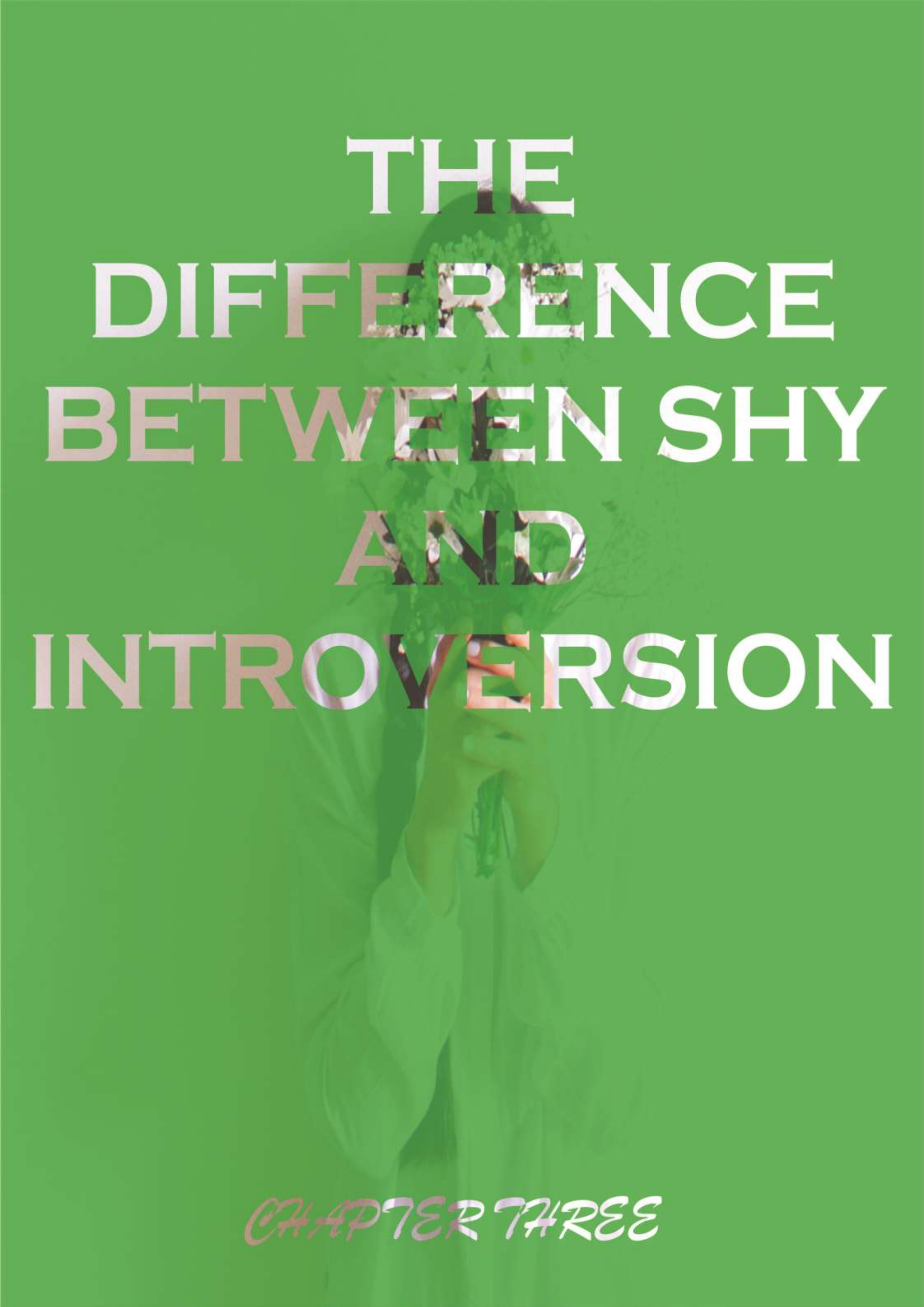
Just take the case of an experiment made by bringing some people who have low self-esteem and some people who have high self-esteem together. Then both groups were allowed to repeat the same affirmations over and over.

After the experiment was done both groups were asked how they felt and the result was that the confident group felt even more confident right after repeating the affirmations while the group who had low self-esteem felt even worse.

WHAT works instead of Self-Affirmations is taking action in the path of what scares you. You have to obey the **competence confidence loop rule** by increasing your Mastery in that activity that scares you, with that Mastery comes confidence.

People have one more excuse. What of those people who are competent and not confident? I have yet to meet those people. I am yet to meet someone who is competent at an activity and lacks confidence. He may choose not to do it and that’s different from been scared.

Now that we have debunked the most common myths of self-confidence and before we look into the strategies of building our confidence. Let's take a look into an equally important topic - the difference between introversion and shyness.



THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN SHY AND INTROVERSION

CHAPTER THREE

Stay true to your own nature. If you like to do things in a slow and steady way, don't let others make you feel as if you have to race. If you enjoy depth, don't force yourself to seek breadth. If you prefer single-tasking to multi-tasking, stick to your guns. Being relatively unmoved by rewards gives you the incalculable power to go your own way.

Susan Cain

Bill Gates is quiet and bookish, but apparently unfazed by others' opinions of him: he's an introvert, but not shy.

Barbra Streisand has an outgoing, larger than life personality, who also battles with a paralyzing case of stage fright: she's a shy extrovert.

We most often confuse these two personality traits together. Shyness and introversion are not the same thing and don't confuse it as such.

Introversion is biological. We are not all born with the same sensitivity. Introverts are people with high sensitivity to noise and energy. They prefer calm and serenity to noise and energy. An extrovert is the exact opposite and loves noise, energy and vibrancy.

Shyness is a totally different topic since shyness is the fear of social interactions. Shyness is the fear of stepping out and being seen.

I'm an introvert but that doesn't make me a shy person. Every time I party, approach stranger and exude enthusiasm, I can literally feel the energy seeping out of me.

I have friends who are miserable when left alone and would probably turn suicidal if left to their devices, these are the extroverts but extroverts can be shy too. A lot of those extroverts are also scared of social interaction and rejection. They have to find a great deal of motivation to step out each time because they would break down psychologically if they don't interact. Socializing is their lifeblood.

You have to identify which personality type you are.

- DO you enjoy people's company and noise(I don't)
- Or do you prefer being quiet

We are in a society that favors the alpha category of the extroverts but there is nothing wrong with being an introvert.

If you are an introvert or an extrovert, you need to accept this as your nature because it's only then that the contents of this book can work for you. I wouldn't advocate you become something that you're not. Confidence is important for our personal success and happiness. However we shouldn't get lose in our search for it and lose touch with who we really are.

This book is not going to transform you into an extrovert if you're not one. The only thing this will do is cure you of your shyness.

Both extroverts and introverts feel fear from time to time. Introversion doesn't stop you from being confident. History reveals that great personality such as- Abraham Lincoln, Eleanor Roosevelt, Emma Watson, Micheal Jordan, Harrison Ford, Christiana Aguilera are all introverts. However, all these people perform confidently every time because confidence has nothing to do with your introversion or extroversion.

HOW SELF-CONFIDENCE REALLY WORKS

CHAPTER FOUR

You gain strength, courage, and confidence by every experience in which you really stop to look fear in the face. You are able to say to yourself, 'I lived through this horror. I can take the next thing that comes along.'

Eleanor Roosevelt

The first day was a disaster. I kept saying no no no to every pretty damsel I saw. I kept bringing up very valid excuses- ***"she is so prettier than me" "she is not my class" "you can't approach her, she's small to you" "she's not my type" "I'll approach her when next I see her" "damn I can't do this, girls don't like been approached in public spaces" and on and on...***

2 years ago I went on a crazy 100 strangers m approach challenge. I dragged every aspect all my life (school, family, work etcetera) to a pause and centered on getting comfortable with approaching strangers.

The second day didn't also play out too well, in fact I didn't approach anyone until the 3rd day when I forced myself to spurt out a squeaky HELLO to a girl at KFC. She replied with an offhand "fine", kept pressing her phone and I got out of there fast. As in a ran out of there!. Whoops! one down, ninety-nine to go.

I was able to eventually do this because I learnt how confidence works. Confidence is not a magical feeling of assurance you get before you talk action, I talked about how people trap themselves by waiting for confidence that never comes in the earlier sections.

The world is full of people who are trying to purchase self-confidence, or manufacture it, or who simply posture it. But you can't fake confidence, you have to earn it. If you ask me, the only way to do that is work. You have to do the work.

Russ Harris

Let me define what confidence is so we get in the same page on this -

Confidence is the feeling of assurance that comes only after you have ruined effort into the practice and mastering of a skill or activity.

WHAT spurred me to take this action was a research I read in a book called **the talent code.**

The author referred to a friend of his who cured his shyness by sitting at spot in a popular space for 30 days and striking up a conversation with everyone who sat there with him.

At first, he messed it up badly because he was so much in his head and didn't engage fully with the stranger we was talking to. He was too self-conscious just as you probably are now.

He would say **"how are you"** and **"how was your day"** over and over until the women gets uncomfortable and walks away. But with time just as you wouldn't believe, he got better. He started making few minutes of conversation and there comes a time he could strike up conversations with ease with anyone that sat down with him.

Now imagine that guy had spent his 30days searching for one magic cure to fear.

DO YOU WANT TO WALK

You see, you reading this are already confident at a lot of things. Everything you could do now - walking, driving, writing, speaking English, swimming, tying your shoe laces are all skills you got by practicing. Not just mindless practice but deliberate practice.

When you were a kid, you kept trying to stand up and kept falling down. Then you started to stay upright for some seconds before you go down again, at this time you were unconsciously practicing deliberately to improve your performance. You kept practicing and you got better with each practice.

Deliberate practice is a highly structured activity engaged in with the specific goal of improving performance.

It involves these steps;

- Finding out the right way to perform
- Exerting effort to perform repeatedly
- Getting informative feedback on your performance(what went right and what could be improved upon)
- Exerting effort to improve upon those things and then repeat the process all over again.

That's what you did as a baby. You knew you wanted to walk, you practice a million times, each time you stood up, you identified what went wrong and right, then you improved on what went right. Voila! You walked and have kept walking ever since.

Same thing with when you learned to drive, swim, speak French, cook etcetera.

I repeat again that there's no universal feeling of confidence that will comes from anywhere to make you confident unless you work hard and gain competence at that thing that scares you.

When you have tried out an activity several times and you have countless success at it to back you up. Then you will have confidence. But not before!

Repeated hard work and Mastery produces what I refer to as Genuine Confidence. The complete belief in ourselves that we can perform adequately not because of positive affirmations or any other superficial entity but on the midnight oils we have burned in practice.

I ended up nailing my target of 100 women after 40days of grueling practice. Woo-hoo!. And you can bet that I can strike up conversation anywhere right now. I wouldn't even have to think about it.

However it's not just easy to work up the courage and build these skills, I wouldn't say it was easy for me to approach the first 30-40 of those women, it was the hardest thing I've ever done. Come to think of it if it were so easy, then everyone would have done it and we would all be confident beyond our wildest dreams.

THE MINDSET OF CONFIDENCE

Carol s. Dweck reveals it in her bestselling book **"mindset"** the two mindset people have. The first is the **fixed mindset** that they are born with some certain skills and talents. We are going to through this mindset straight out of the window.

The second mindset is the **growth mindset.** And this is the mindset that places emphasis on effort in order to gain skills and talent. You can't build your confidence with anything else short of this.

You have to develop this mindset that you can gain confidence bringing competence at anything with practice and effort. All those social pros, amazing public speakers and sales masters are people with more practice than you. When you put in that much practice, you get the confidence. However there is this thing called fear that stops us cold in our tracks when we want to practice, and we are not getting anywhere until we analyze this fear and see if it's possible to overcome it. Is it even possible? That's what we will look into in the next chapter.

EVOLUTION, FEAR AND THE PRETTY FACE

CHAPTER ONE

I want you to do complete some quick exercises for me.

NUMBER ONE

First of all I want you to stop thinking and focus on your breath immediately after reading this. Drop your phone or stand up from your PC and start breathing deeply, breathe in, breathe out and just silence your thoughts for 2 minutes. Start!

Did you do it? If you didn't perform the exercise you had better go back now because this is the most important thing you need to do.

Alright here is what happened. If you performed the exercise and you are normal human who hasn't being meditating for 10 years or more. You just failed miserably on your attempt to quiet your mind. As you tried to focus on your breath your mind kept drifting away.

NUMBER TWO

Here's the second exercise. I want you to do a little tricky exercise for me, I don't want you to picture a red Lamborghini with black wheels racing down your street. I want you to take charge of your thoughts for 180 seconds and refuse to see anything red or car like in your dream.

If you are human and you have seen a Lamborghini before, not until did you picture a red car, you saw a red Lamborghini racing down your street several times in your head..

Now when you were performing these two exercises did you notice how little power you have over your mind. And that you can only control a part of your mind.

This is because our minds are two and not one.

As you were trying to stop thinking and not think of a Lamborghini, you were taking charge of the aspect of your mind that is under your control. But did you also notice that you were able to observe as the other dimension of your mind went on its spiral thinking spree.

Can you now see that there is a **watcher** and a **thinker!**

This part of your mind that wanders is popularly known in the zen world as the **monkey mind** and the part of your mind that you can control is the **observing mind.** It notices when the thinking mind goes awry but the crazy thing is that this most people are not well aware of this.

In building your confidence, most experts will tell you to fight your fear, think positive, recite positive Affirmations and picture yourself winning. That's bullshit because your monkey mind will think of what it wants and what do you guess it will think of? Yes, it will picture you failing and you know mental pictures trigger emotions. And since mental images of failure equals feelings of fear. BAM!

You are hooked.

Most people have both dimensions of their minds fused together. They don't differentiate their real thoughts (courtesy of the observing mind) from their wandering thoughts (courtesy of monkey mind). But it's not their fault. It's evolutions fault. Evolution is a bitch.

LET'S TIME TRAVEL FOR A LITTLE WHILE.

Millions of years ago when man was still evolving, he lived in the wild, there was no skyscrapers, missiles, vehicles, machines gun or cutting edge medical facilities. He lived out there with all those dangerous animals such as cave bears, lions, saber toothed tigers etcetera who would love nothing than to eat man for dinner.

So thanks to evolution he developed the impulsive part of the brain called the limbic cortex. This is responsible for the monkey mind. With this limbic cortex man could survive by always being alert and ready for danger. Man's need then was so simple then and wasn't buggered down with all these issues of success, confidence, productivity and happiness. All he needed was;

- Shelter
- Food
- Water and.
- Hot jungle sex

With the monkey mind, he was able to interpret simple signs such as a broken twig or a paw print on the ground as possible signs of a leopard lurking nearly so he could swiftly escape. The **monkey mind** thinks of all the possibilities of how things could go wrong and how he could easily get slaughtered by a wild animal.

There was real danger then and by impulsive negative thinking all the time, he could survive. Without the limbic cortex, there wouldn’t be an us here today.

This is why habit change, confidence building and procrastination is excruciatingly hard for most people.

Your mind didn't evolve for you to be confident or productive, it evolved so that you can survive and that's all it’s interested in. Though there are none of those scary dangers here anymore, however our mind still interprets a lot of things as potential danger, like that pretty face of a stranger.

Anything that you're not familiar with such as talking to stranger, walking in a dark alley, learning a new language, public speaking, cold calling, rock climbing will trigger your limbic cortex and your monkey mind will kick into action. Your mind is meant to protect so it comes up with all the possible scenarios of how things could go wrong. This then triggers the black(fear) emotions and we go into a flight or fight reaction.

Thanks to evolution again, we do have a **prefrontal cortex** now. This is the part of our brain that is responsible for rational thoughts (your observing mind).

Now listen to me, the problem you are having now is that you have fused both minds together. Every time the **monkey mind** is active and shows you pictures of you failing, of you not being enough and tells you that you're inadequate, you believe it. Which is the dumbest thing you could possibly do and most people do. I was responsible for this too earlier in my life and I still struggle with it at times (I'm not perfect after all).

The key to **Genuine confidence** is refusing to fuse with our **monkey mind** and to also against all common not fight it.

If you fight your negative thoughts by using positive Affirmations, arguing with your thoughts by bringing out evidence that your adequacy. You're only fighting with millions of years of evolution. And it's a fight you can't possibly win.

See your mind as garden that grows at a remarkable pace of microseconds. In these gardens there are weeds (monkey mind thoughts) and flowers (deliberate thoughts).

If you go into this garden and you cut off all those grasses. Does that mean you have gotten rid of them forever? No! They will keep coming back because that's the way gardens work. Fighting it is foolhardy.

I'll teach you how to separate from your thoughts in the coming chapter, how to get comfortable with awful feelings so that you can be able to practice and build your confidence not in their absence but because of them.

Excited?

HOW TO START BUILDING YOUR CONFIDENCE



CHAPTER SIX

What holds you back is not fear, but your attitude towards it. The tighter you hold on to the attitude that fear is something 'bad' and you can't do the things you want until it goes away, the more stuck you will be.

Russ Harris

You are a lousy writer...

Nobody will read this anyway.

You're just a shitty overachiever from nowhere..

You are having writers block. Real writers don't go through this, you are a fake...

These and several other thoughts are what is going through my mind as I'm about to begin this chapter. I haven't written an eBook before and my **monkey mind** is giving me a hell of a lashing out. It wants me to quit and go do something comfortable (and unproductive).

Now if I didn't know better about the monkey aspect of my mind, I would remain fused to my wandering thoughts, I would believe it and really go do something else.

I can't possibly thank Steve Hayes enough for coming up with this life changing practice of distancing from our thoughts and Russ Harris for popularizing it in his bestselling book **"The happiness trap".** As I was going through the words on the pages of the books 3 years ago, I was floored by how big a dummy I had been. I have been fusing with my thoughts all my life and that is what was killing my confidence.

Right now we would go into four strategies of how to build lasting genuine confidence

- Distancing from your thoughts
- Making room for your feelings
- Self compassion
- Commitment to deliberate practice

Distancing from your thoughts

Now as my mind is giving the so so awfl lashing out. I could have easily believed this or I could gather my forces up and fight it by remembering all the times I've written popular posts and gotten healthy feedback.

Will the work for the moment? You bet it will. But will it stop the thoughts from coming up tomorrow, (coughs) will it stop it from coming up as I'm about to write the next chapter? The answer is no.

I remember reading a life experience shared by Nicholas Cole on Quora. He wrote in a answer to a question about the shyness issue he had then was that he spent too much time in his head talking and arguing with his monkey mind that he was paying zero attention to what the girl beside him way saying.

He would say **"hello",** argue with himself in his head and zone out of hearing the girls response of **"hey I'm fine and you".** He would then say his stereotyped **"how is your day",** then he said **"how is your day going"** before be could stop himself and process what the girl just said.

Arguing with yourself about your worth or positive Affirmations are next to dog's shit. They won't make you present enough to practice and gain confidence.

PLAN C OF CONFIDENCE BUILDING.

There is a better way. And that is identifying your thoughts and taking their power away. We are not going to fight the awful thoughts and feelings nor charm them away. We are simply going to acknowledge them and move on.

First you need to accept that your monkey mind is out to protect you and it does this by bringing stories, opinions and images that aren't always true. And you are the only one that is responsible for not believing it.

First you need to practice mindfulness and become more aware of your wandering thoughts. Practice noticing your thoughts and the tools below for the next few days.

As the thoughts comes saying **“you are a loser" "you have zero confidence" "you will mess this up" "you don't have it in you"** etcetera. Just identify these as stories your monkey mind are coming up with a sense of amusement and say **"oh it's the loser story again"** or **"I can sense self-depreciating thoughts coming along, hmmm"** or **"wow, the you don't have it in your story again"**

Now that you have named the thoughts for what they are, check if they still bothered you as they used to? You would notice you have taken their power away once you identify them and you didn't use one word of Affirmation!

Another way to distance from your thoughts is hearing your thoughts in funny squeaky voices. Recall a self-defeating thought you used to have and play it in your mind in voice of mickey mouse, James Bond, your favorite artist, Obamas voice etc.

Now try it for the next 5 minutes.

I'm sure you chuckled as you repeated **"you are a loser"** in mickey mouse’s voice. There is no way under the sun that you would be able to take this thought seriously anymore.

The other way you can equally use is to simply thank your mind after this. Say **"oh the I'm a loser story again, thanks mind"** or **"thanks for sharing this story with me mind, you are so caring".** You can come up with your own variations and just play with this.

Combine these tricks together and work with them for some days. The goal is not to keep using these tricks, who wants to thank their minds forever right? The goal is to practice with this mind-tools until you can distance from your thoughts automatically without even thinking about it.

It was with this mind tool that I was able to ignore every excuse my mind came up with after the 3rd day of my challenge and I started approaching women. But hey I haven't talked about how to handle the terrible terrible feelings those thoughts bring about.

DO YOU WANT TO RUN

Those crazy butterflies in our bellies. I'm sorry to tell you but those butterflies won't leave even after you have disarmed your **monkey mind.** You can't stop the thoughts, you have only accepted them but they will still trigger the feelings.

So what do we do? What hope have we?

The way out is to use a similar technique used earlier to disarm your thoughts. How? You accept the feelings, name them and thank them for caring.

Whenever, you feel the emotions of fear and anxiety rising in you. Simply notice it and use the same skeptical mind to look at the feeling from a distance. Don't say **"I'm afraid"** or **"oh shit, I'm scared"** or anything like that.

Try this instead, feel the emotions, don't fight them and simply call it by its name;

"The emotion of fear being felt" or "There is the presence of anxiety ". You can also thank your mind by saying **"hmm, the old fear is back, thank you mind"** and **"thanks mind for bringing this anxiety so I can up my game" or simple "thanks mind".**

If you really try this out there in situations that scared you before. You'd notice a dramatic increase in your resolve to make a move, because you have taken away the power of those feelings the instant you named them.

It's not that the feelings go away, it's just that they are not your entire world anymore. You become able to hijack your prefrontal cortex from the clutches of your monkey mind and think clearly. You'd be able to access the situation and say confidently "okay, I'm having an anxiety episode right now but I can do this". You'd be able to accept the feelings not as a signs to quit but as a sign to take one step forward.

The negative thoughts and butterflies are still there, it's just that they don't bother you anymore. You are now free to take action in spite of their presence. I'm sure you have heard the phrase **"just do it in spite of your fear?"** This is what they probably meant but they didn't explain it.

The other two strategies you need to build your confidence is not as complicated as the ones above but they are equally important.

A LESSON INTO SELF COMPASSION

You are well aware that with all these tools, distancing from my thoughts and disarming my feelings, I still couldn't approach women until the third day.

I'm saying this because self-compassion is very important in your journey to EPIC CONFIDENCE. You will definitely mess up and fuse with your thoughts and emotions several times. You'll backslide and fail to man up on your first few tries.

You have to approach this with a lot of self-kindness and compassion.

You have to accept this and not fuse with your thoughts as it starts calling you a loser for not trying hard enough. Be kind to yourself, talk to yourself as you would to a friend.. Of course I got a lot of harsh comments from my **monkey mind** on the first two days but I refused to fuse with them. I identified those thoughts for what they are and I thanked them.

Then, I geared myself up and went out to try again and again and again until I said the first hello. This is the exact mindset you need for you to succeed at this.

You have to be okay with fumbling miserably at the first. Rome wasn’t built in a day! You have to let go of all your wants to be perfect and all that. It's time to let all the self-compassion you can manage in. Thank you.

COMMITMENT TO DELIBERATE PRACTICE

I talked about deliberate practice earlier and I have to repeat it because it is the last step in the process of building EPIC CONFIDENCE.

Before you do or try anything you have to commit to deliberate practice.

The first step is that you get every material (Books, tapes, videos, advices, courses) you can about how to perform. Let’s say you want to speak in public, do stand-up or even have sex, get books on these topics.

The next step is that to practice over and over again. Get feedback on your performance and find out what could be improved upon.

Then you practice over and over again improving on your weak points and repeating the process. Then as you begin to amount success upon success, your self-confidence keeps rising until it blast through the roof.

I didn't just start approaching women without any ideas. I had read a lot of books on social skills. I had taken more than one online course and watched more than some YouTube videos.

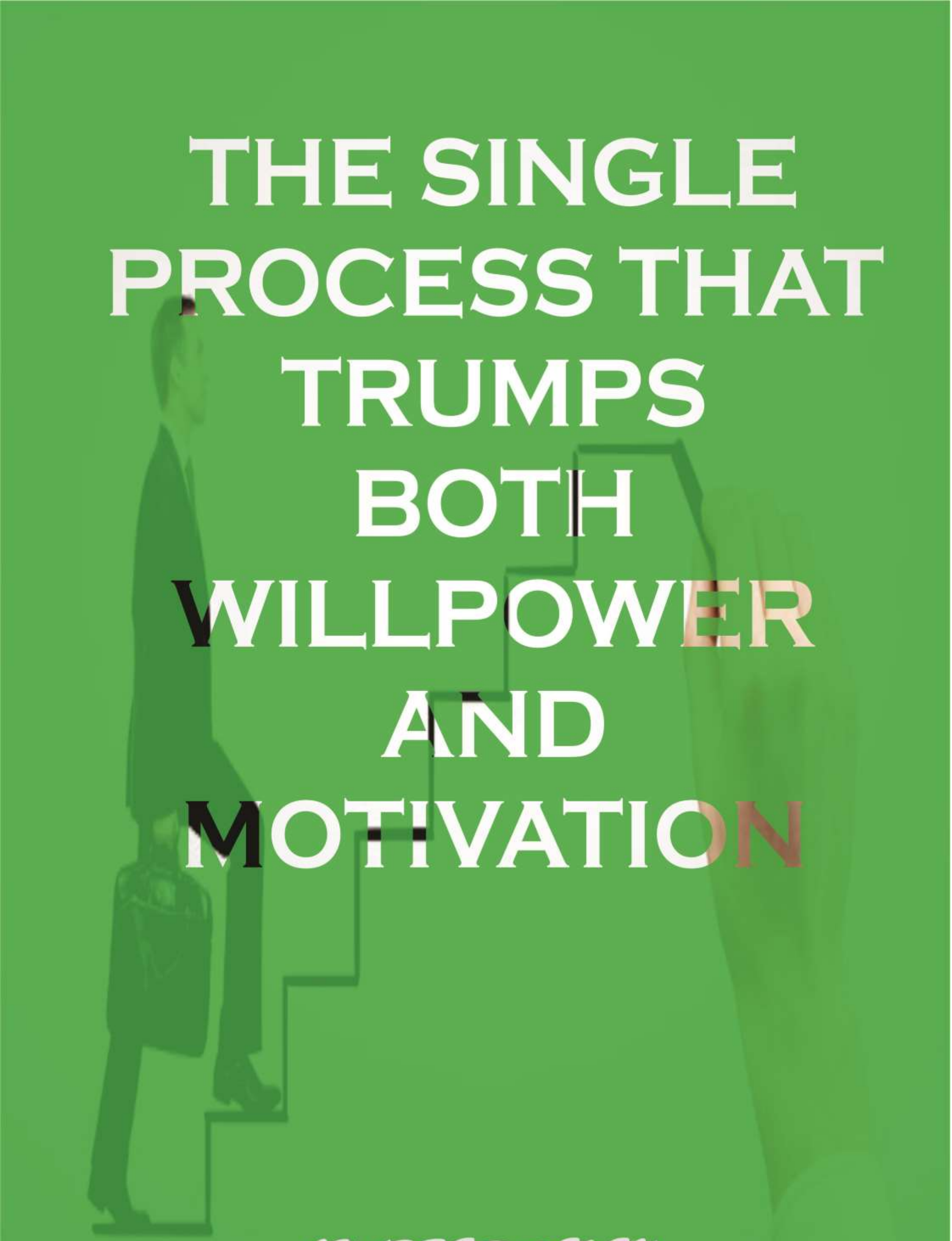
Remember that confidence comes after competence. But don't go perfectionist on me with this. You don't have to know everything on the planet. Just read one or two books or better still take a comprehensive online course on mastering that skill.

Then, you go out there, practice, improve and repeat.

Cool right? Now you have more than enough tools to be more confident than your wildest dreams.

But do you know I still have more?

THE SINGLE PROCESS THAT TRUMPS BOTH WILLPOWER AND MOTIVATION



CHAPTER SEVEN

Every time you encounter something that forces you to “handle it,” your self-esteem is raised considerably. You learn to trust that you will survive, no matter what happens. And in this way your fears are diminished immeasurably.

Susan Jeffers

We have gone a really long way but there is still a tricky pitfall to watch out for.

As effective as these tools I've shared with you are, it's not easy to carry them out with perfection. Your monkey mind have had millions of years of evolution ahead of you, it won't just quiet down without a fight.

Each time you trump over it, it will keep getting easier and easier until it literally becomes effortless until you face an entirely new situation where you have to start the process all over again.

You might be motivated now that because you can disarm your negative thoughts and feelings that you're now ready to go. You are but don't be deceived it's that easy. You remember that I said only "hello" on the 3rd day? That didn't happen to chance, it was deliberate.

Beating the monkey mind takes time and practice! You have to practice distancing from your thoughts and feelings over and over again before you can beat the monkey mind with ease.

Make it so small to start that you can't possibly say no - leo babauta

You shouldn't test your monkey mind by trying to walk into a group of ten beautiful strangers right now though it's possible with the skills I've taught you (possible but not the ideal). There is an equal chance however that your monkey mind will snuff out your motivation and make you believe this doesn't work.

So the right way is to take things extremely slowly. Break that big goal of yours down until it's so small you can't help but do it.

Want to approach strangers easily? Start by smiling to one stranger at first. When you are comfortable with that? Get comfortable staying at a public space all alone. When you are

comfortable with that, start with just an hello to one stranger day. Then after some days, follow the **"Hello"** with **"how are you doing"** with the next stranger. Then level up like that.

Want to public speak? Please don't start with Ted, don't start with your local society group. Start with pitching to one person. Just one!. Get your friend and present your speech to him, then present to three, then to 30 and level up like that. Franklin veaux, a popular speaker and author did exactly just this and now he speaks to thousands of people confidently.

You didn't learn swimming by diving in the deep end on your first day, you started in the shallow part. Start building your confidence from the shallow end. It's sexy but don't seek to hijack control from your monkey mind that easily. Take it slow. Think big but start small.

This is the single process that trumps Willpower, motivation and grit any day. **Take. Things. Slowly.**



TOOLS TO 10X YOUR CONFIDENCE 10X FASTER

CHAPTER EIGHT

We have since covered a whole lot of ground about our minds and how to effectively build our confidence. But we are not done yet. There are still some crazy science findings and life-hacks that you can still merge with the knowledge you have already to 10x the growth of your confidence.

Let's get into it.

WHAT GORILLAS CAN TEACH YOU ABOUT CONFIDENCE

Recent research coming out of Harvard University, The University of Oregon, The University of Texas and many other places is revealing that powerful and effective leaders not only share similar mindsets, but also similar hormone levels. More specifically, powerful leaders tend to have higher levels of testosterone and lower levels of cortisol.

Higher levels of testosterone (in both men and women) lead to increased feelings of confidence giving you more power over the limbic cortex. Meanwhile, lower levels of cortisol lead to decreased anxiety and an improved ability to deal with stress (actually depresses the limbic cortex).

Here's what this all means: if you enjoy these hormone levels, then you are biologically primed to be more assertive, confident, and relaxed. At the same time, you will be less reactive to stress and more likely to handle pressure situations well. In other words, the correct hormone levels can make you feel more confident and less stressed.

Sounds good, right?

Amy Cuddy a researcher of Harvard business school conducted a study on a group of college students. Some were asked to assume a high Power pose, as in to spread out and take up space like a gorilla. The other group were told to assume a low Power pose by closing up and try their best to appear small and frail. Then the hormones levels of both groups were measured.

The groups with high power body pose had a spike in their blood testosterone levels and a drastic drop in their blood levels of cortisol.

POWER posing gives you a false sense of confidence, however this false confidence is not useless. Though you can't Powerpose yourself into every challenge but it definitely gives a false sense of certainty, the type you get only after true practice for a short period of time.

Entrepreneur Derek Halpern of social triggers talks about how he used this trick of faking it till he makes it in his college days and how it worked for him. I have since read multiple success stories on this theory so have I have no doubt about the effectiveness of this. It works.

But don't take this as the only cure there is to anxiety and shyness. The monkey mind is tough and you need every tools in your arsenal. I think it would be so much better if you combine the earlier tools of disarming your thoughts and feelings with this.

Take charge if your thoughts and feelings like we covered earlier and hack your body with Power-posing to boost your sense of confidence. I think with that, growing your confidence in any aspect of your life just got 10x easier and faster. Who said you can't eat your bread and still have it?

FRIENDS! OH! FRIENDS

I love reading Nelson Wang's blog because he talks about this a lot and it really makes me feel connected to him.

Neurologist confirms that we have some special neurons called **mirror neuron** (another evolution MOJO) in our heads. These neurons are responsible for picking up cues such as habits, mannerisms, skills etcetera that we frequently come into contact with, and they are responsible for inputting these things into our very own behaviors. This is why you share mannerisms, habits and goals with your closest friends.

It's how our ancestors learned skills from each other as they weren't yet capable of speech. And that's why who you associate with matters more than a lot. All those statements of you being the average your five closest friends are not cliche, they are actually hard facts backed with scientific evidence.

If you are always in the environment of shy people and negative people who keeps strengthening your **monkey mind**. You've got next to zero chance of breaking out of your mind block.

You have to make the conscious decision of creating a suitable environment for yourself that supports your confidence building. This is not optional! It's a must do.

Stay away from your shy and the negative ones for a while please. Do everything in your power to stay around those who are competent at those things that still scares you. Remember that deliberate practice is how you build your confidence.

Refuse to stay around people who will strengthen your monkey mind with their excuses about how it's hard to do that thing confidently. Surround yourself with awesome people who are killing it already. As Nelson Wang normally puts it **"awesomeness is contagious, stay with awesome people and their awesomeness will rub off on you".**

BLOCKBUSTING

Some years before I learnt how to separate from my thoughts I came up with a pretty crazy life hack to force myself to take action. It is more of a refine of the carrot and stick motivation thing anyway.

WHAT I did was that I sometimes forced myself to approach beautiful women by making a bet with someone with something I can't afford to lose.

I was able to give a public speech some years back and not run away by giving my life savings to the guy living in the apartment opposite to mine. He spent half of my money before I gave the speech and every alert I got was hell. Since, it took me months to save all that money.

So, imagine you gave out your life savings to someone in a bet in other to say hello to a stranger? You just chuckled right.

WHAT about losing your $20,000 car if you don't make those sales calls before midnight. This type of motivation works but I've noticed it's not really ideal because it's stressful to keep making the bets over and over again in order to amount enough practice that results in genuine confidence. But this works and I won't ignore it just because I hate it.

There is a game to your usage of this however. You can use this for the first few tries and as it gets easier to disarm your **monkey mind**. Drop it.

Another thing I've learned that really worked to build your confidence is if you celebrate your success.

I'm just starting to make YouTube videos and as I'm building my confidence to do this. I'm learning to praise every step I take. I celebrated my first video as if I had won a million dollar lottery. By celebrating your success, it charges you up to try even harder and in that way, Mastery comes faster. And with it CONFIDENCE!

TRAVEL ALONE

I have two friends Tom Jetson and Eben rizzo. I do hear this theory that traveling the world boosts your confidence, changes you life entirely and blah blah blah but I've never seen it work firsthand. My friends gave me that opportunity to witness it firsthand.

Both Tom and Eben are what you would call quiet people alright. They preferred staying at home and working on projects or watching TV to going out and having fun. They were always scared of meeting new people but they were fun to be with. And Eben was the worst of the two.

Tom was the first to travel in early 2015, from Nigeria to Buenos Aires and then to four other countries before staying for an extended period in India.

Eben also traveled late that 2015 but he went way larger. He booked a round the world trip with a travel agency and traveled to 12 countries all around the world in a trip planned for 13 months (I really hate him for this because the call rate to those countries are crippling).

That's not the interesting part anyway. The mind blowing change was noticeable in the airport as I went to pick each one up.

They already stood up straighter, there was this enthusiasm in their tone of voice and they were so lively it began to wear me out (so I set a goal of traveling to 20 countries sometimes in the future just to spite them).

When I think about it now. I think Blockbusting had a little part to play in their transformation, since if they stayed shy and refused to communicate in a strange country, they would have a hard time doing anything or going anywhere, and I think the monkey mind will be more quiet since everyone is a stranger and communication seems to be the only thing to do.

I am sure traveling the world will boost your social confidence enormously. However if you are after confidence in another aspect of your life, ignore this and put into use the tools we have covered earlier.

Now it remains only one thing.

HOW TO PUT ALL YOU HAVE LEARNT INTO PRACTICE IN YOUR LIFE

CHAPTER NINE

You have just been empowered with various tools about how to build your confidence. You now know the common mistakes, the way confidence really works and how to overcome the biggest obstacles(negative feelings and thoughts) to confidence and how to even accelerate your confidence growth and get where you want to be faster.

All the same, all these can be overwhelming. So that urges the question of how can you put this into immediate use in your life?

Here's what I would advice you to do;

1. Pick one aspect of your life you want to get confident in.

2. Get knowledge about how to practice confidently in that area.

3. Raise your awareness and practice distancing from your thoughts and feelings beforehand.

4. Practice self-compassion and vulnerability(be gentle on yourself and expect to fail at first)

5. Start with small actions, improve and level up as you go.

6. Celebrate every success every step of the way.

7. Input the tools of accelerating your success - power pose, get confident friends and blockbust yourself or even travel the world if you can afford it.

And with that we come to the end of this e-book. I hope you enjoyed reading it as much as I enjoyed writing it for you.

Footnotes

Happiness trap by Russ harris.

Research papers of steven hayes,

Mindset by Carol dweck .

The 5 second rule.

Feel the fear and do it anyway by Susan Jeffers.

Quiet by Susan Cain.

Amy cuddy ted talk and her book “presence”.

Harvard business reviews.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

James haforlarin is a writer, graphic designer and a prolific writer. But that’s boring isn’t it? James is a guy that really cares and wants a better life for himself and everyone else. Subscribe to his newsletter on here